

Strategic Alignment and Social Media Behavior of U.S. Congress Members: Trump as a Coordination Signal

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Motivation & Research Questions

Members of Congress balance **national-party loyalty** (signaling alignment with a popular leader) against **local accountability** (representing district preferences). Trump’s Truth Social posts are high-salience national signals that rapidly structure elite attention.

- **Strategic problem:** On controversial issues, Republican members may remain strategically silent rather than engage with Trump’s signal in public, while taking clearer positions in roll-call votes. Republicans who do engage on social media are likely less constrained by national and local pressures, and more align with Trump. Democrats will forcefully amplify their original signal and seize the opportunity to increase engagement to counter Trump.
- **RQ1:** How do members adjust attention and stance when Trump issues a high-salience signal?
- **RQ2:** Do politicians follow national cues even when they conflict with district opinion?
- **RQ3:** Under strong national signals, does partisan loyalty still carry electoral cost (will do)?

The Two exogenous signals (pilot approach): Trump’s Ukraine Stance Shift

Event 1 — Blame Ukraine ukraine_blame_01 Feb 19 2025
“...Volodymyr Zelenskyy talked the United States into spending \$350 Billion... Zelenskyy, with no cards to play, is not the innocent man he portrays himself to be...”
Position: Blame Ukraine/Zelensky; anti-Ukraine framing.

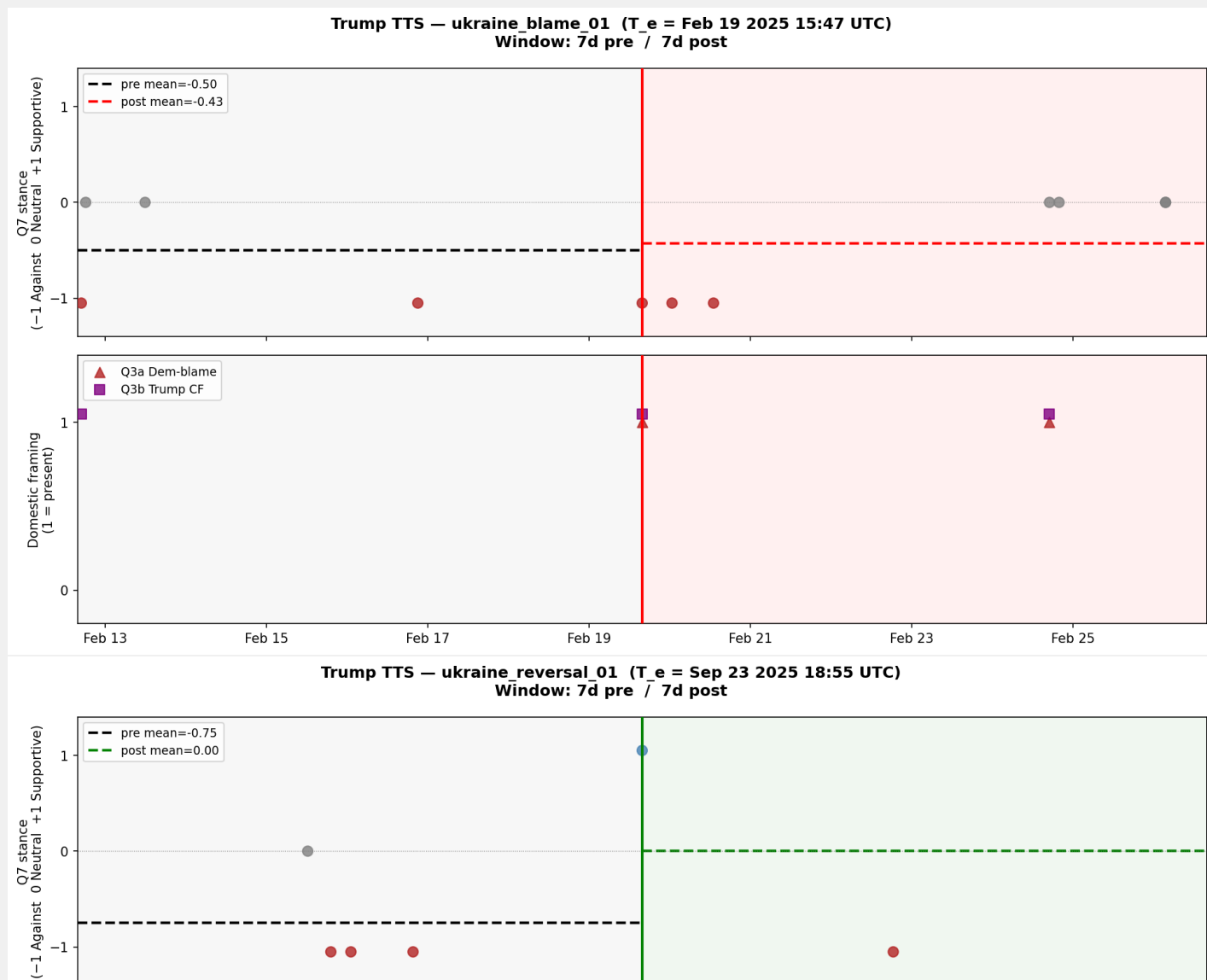
Event 2 — Reversal (pro-Ukraine) ukraine_reversal_01 Sep 23 2025
“...I think Ukraine, with the support of the European Union, is in a position to fight and WIN all of Ukraine back in its original form...”
Position: Pro-Ukraine reversal; endorses EU + U.S. support.

Both posts are sharp, unanticipated changes in Trump’s publicly stated Ukraine position.

Data Sources

- Congressional social-media panel.** 2M tweets from 118th–119th Members of U.S. Congress (2022–Jan 2026), plus governors.
- Trump signal corpus.** Truth Social posts (Feb 2022–Jan 2026); T_e identified via keyword search + researcher review.
- Stance classification (LLMs).** Relevance and Stance: Qwen2.5, GPT-4o, DeBERTaV3-NLI.
- District covariates.** 2020 Trump/Biden vote share; CES policy preferences; demographics. Roll-call votes.

Stance Validation: Ukraine Events



Stance: Descriptive Patterns

Across 22 events (exogenous, not necessarily initiated by Trump), Democratic and Republican support for or opposition to Trump.

	Democrats	Republicans
Avg % oppose	>80%	~18%
Avg % neutral	~12%	~15%
Avg % support	<5%	~65%
Highest support	7.3%	83.7%

Ukraine (Rep: 49% support) and **NATO threat** (Rep: 43% support) are clearest exceptions to GOP alignment. **Tariffs** shows highest GOP support (83.7%).

Empirical Strategy: RD in Time

Running variable: $\tilde{d}_t = t - T_e$ (event-relative day). **Cutoff:** T_e .

$$Y_{it} = \underbrace{\alpha_j}_{\text{member FE}} + \underbrace{\beta \mathbf{1}[t \geq T_e]}_{\text{interest: within-member RD jump}} + \underbrace{\gamma \tilde{d}_t + \delta (\mathbf{1}[t \geq T_e] \cdot \tilde{d}_t)}_{\text{local-linear trend (each side)}} + \varepsilon_{it}$$

- **Two outcomes** estimated separately:
 - Y_{it}^{attn} = Ukraine-tweet share of all tweets (defined $\forall$ member-days).
 - Y_{it}^{stance} = mean Qwen stance score (*conditional* on ≥ 1 Ukraine tweet).
- Window ± 7 days; SE clustered by member.

Identification: Continuity of potential outcomes through T_e absent the Trump post.

RD Main Results: Discontinuity at T_e

Member FE absorbed; SE clustered by member.

Event / Outcome	β	SE	p	N
ukraine_blame_01 (Feb 19 2025)				
	+0.030	0.014	0.037**	3,922
Attention share				
Stance	−0.075	0.083	0.370	803
ukraine_reversal_01 (Sep 23 2025)				
	+0.030	0.011	0.007***	3,911
Attention share				
Stance	+0.252	0.153	0.102	589

Takeaway

Both events produce a significant within-member engagement *attention share* at T_e . As hypothesized, stance is not significant, effects are mixed across Democrats and Republicans.

RD Visual: Blame Event

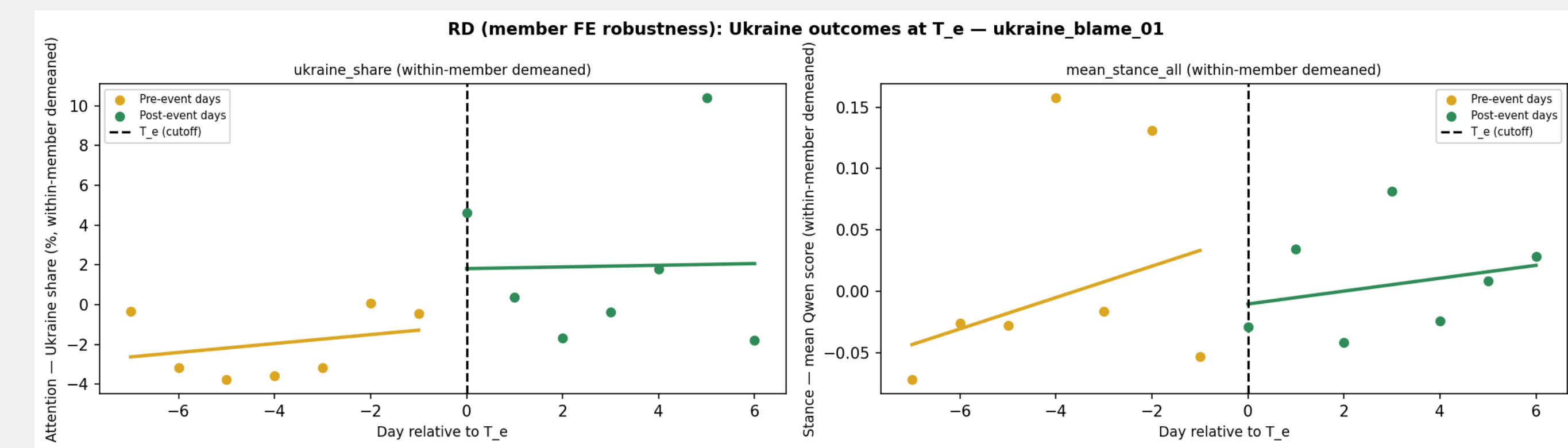


Figure: ukraine_blame_01 (Feb 19 2025): scatter = within-member demeaned daily means; lines = local-linear fit on demeaned outcomes (pre = gold; post = green). Within-member jump at T_e : $\hat{\beta} = +0.030$, se = 0.014.

RD Visual: Reversal Event

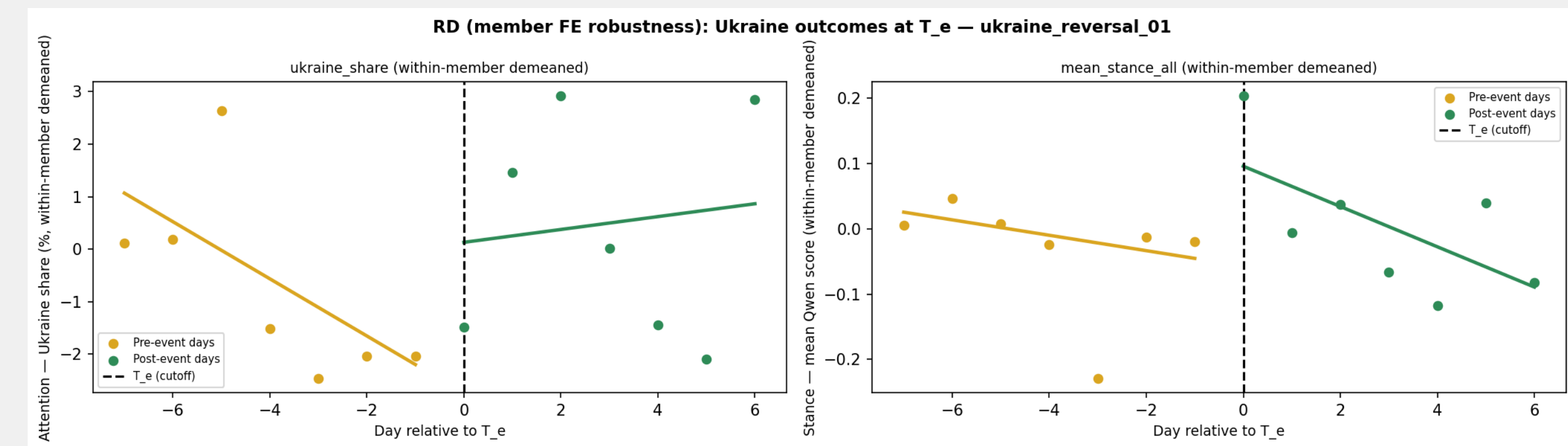


Figure: ukraine_reversal_01 (Sep 23 2025): scatter = within-member demeaned daily means; lines = local-linear fit on demeaned outcomes (pre = gold; post = green). Within-member jump at T_e : $\hat{\beta} = +0.030$, se = 0.011.

Heterogeneous Effects by Party, Trump Vote Share, and Local Support for Ukraine

Member FE, SE clustered by member.

High/Low Trump: 2020 Trump vote share, High/Low Districts: local support for Ukraine

Attention (Ukraine share of all tweets)

Subgroup	RD jump	SE	p	N
ukraine_blame_01				
R	+0.020	0.019	0.315	1,893
D	+0.042	0.021	0.051*	2,029
D Low T	+0.040	0.021	0.059*	1,985
ukraine_reversal_01				
R	+0.011	0.015	0.463	1,873
D	+0.047	0.016	0.004***	2,038
D Low T	+0.054	0.016	0.001***	1,997
D (Low T, High Local)	+0.060	0.019	0.002***	1,286

Stance (conditional on Ukraine tweet)

Subgroup	RD jump	SE	p	N
ukraine_blame_01				
R	−0.208	0.097	0.035**	386
R High T	−0.186	0.099	0.065*	365
R (High T, Low Local)	−0.279	0.144	0.058*	235
D	+0.104	0.130	0.425	417
ukraine_reversal_01				
R	+0.463	0.226	0.045**	244
R High T	+0.327	0.203	0.111	224
R (High T, Low Local)	+0.366	0.300	0.230	138
D	+0.087	0.200	0.663	345

Findings and Conclusion

When the issue is controversial (Republican 49% support for Ukraine):

Attention: Democrats drive both RD jumps; Strongest in Low-Trump, High-Local districts (+6.0pp, $p = 0.002$). Republicans show a positive but statistically insignificant shift in attention. (*strategic silence*).

Stance: Engaged Republicans (High-Trump, Low-Local districts) *do* align with Trump when they tweet: amplifying his blame framing (−0.21, $p = 0.035$) and following his reversal (+0.46, $p = 0.045$). Democrats show no stance shift (Support Ukraine forcefully).

Next Steps

- event-study pre-trend tests, MAGA vs. establishment heterogeneity, expand to additional events (national controversial vs not), Synthetic Control, roll-call votes